NETWORK ANALYSIS · ELEVEN CONTACTS, THIRTY-THREE IDEAS

Eleven Doors

Every contact you named, the industry they sit in as it actually looks right now, and three ideas each — one realistic, one ambitious, one creative. Plus the one pattern that shows up in four of them.

September 2026   Researched, not brainstormed

The overlaps section is the important one

The pattern worth seeing before anything else

I researched all eleven industries independently. One structure appeared in four of them, unprompted:

Somebody deducts money from what they owe your contact, the deduction is often wrong, and nobody audits it.

THE SAME BUSINESS, FOUR MARKETS

MARKET	WHO DEDUCTS	SCALE OF THE LEAK	YOUR DOOR
Medical practices	Insurers, via silent underpayment	~1.2% of collections	Your father
Food manufacturers	Retailers, via chargebacks and deductions	**1–5% of gross retail revenue**	Deep Foods
Hotel owners	Franchisors, via fees and marketing levies	10–12% of room revenue	Tarsadia / AAHOA

MARKET	WHO DEDUCTS	SCALE OF THE LEAK	YOUR DOOR
Cigar makers	FDA, via user fees now ruled inapplicable	$100M+ collected 2016–2023	Your cousin

You have already built the engine for the first one. The mechanics barely change: ingest the remittance or statement file, compare against what the agreement actually says, surface the gap, generate the dispute.

That is not four businesses. It is **one machine with four doors, and you have a personal relationship behind every door.** If nothing else in this document survives scrutiny, that observation should.

Honest triage

WHAT EACH CONTACT IS ACTUALLY FOR

CONTACT	BEST USE	USABLE WHEN
Physician network	Customers	**Now**
Deep Foods	Design partner + customer	**Now**
Crypto friends	Design partners + intros	**Now**
Uncle Rupen	Paid work + operating education	**Now**
Cigar cousin	Advisor first, partner second	**Now** (as advisor)
California friend	Partner in a specific deal	Now, with a warning
Amneal	Teacher, not customer	Now, framed correctly
Goldman cousin	Market intelligence	Now (intel), later (capital)

CONTACT	BEST USE	USABLE WHEN
Former VC boss	Relationship to repair	Now, with no ask attached
Tarsadia	Capital / distribution	Only with traction
Falguni Nayar	Judgment, one conversation	Only with something real

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DOOR 01

Your father and the physician network

WHERE THIS STANDS

The 835 scanner is built and tested. You're gathering files. Everything below assumes that proceeds in parallel.

REALISTIC

Sell the billing-company report card

Practices pay a billing company 4–9% of collections and have *no way to evaluate them*. There is no scorecard. Build one: denial rate, days in A/R, net collection rate, underpayment capture, all benchmarked against the specialty.

It runs on the same 835 files you already parse, requires no new sales motion, and it is the single most gossiped-about topic among practice owners. Sell it as an annual audit of a vendor they can't otherwise judge — $1,500–3,000, low effort, and it makes the underpayment finding land harder.

AMBITIOUS

Payer contract benchmarking

Once you've processed remittances for twenty-plus practices you will know something almost nobody knows: what each payer *actually* allows for each procedure, by specialty, in your region.

That powers a far more valuable conversation than claim recovery: *"You're at 138% of Medicare for cardiac cath. The regional median for groups your size is 161%. Here's what that gap is worth annually."* Contract negotiation support is a much higher-value engagement, and the data accrues only to whoever has been reading everyone's remittances. Get aggregate de-identified data rights into your first BAA or you cannot do this later.

CREATIVE

The revenue leak index, published

Publish an annual anonymized report: *"What independent cardiology practices in the Northeast lost to payer underpayment in 2026."* Specialty societies would circulate it, trade press would cover it, and inbound leads arrive without outreach.

You have the data as a byproduct of the work. Publishing it converts a services business into an authority, which is how you eventually reach practices your father has never met.

DOOR 02

Your crypto friends

WHERE THE INDUSTRY ACTUALLY IS

The GENIUS Act created a federal licensing regime for payment stablecoins. Regulators **missed the July 18, 2026 deadline** for final rules; the effective date is January 18, 2027 or 120 days after final rules issue. Issuers face reserve, licensing, audit and disclosure requirements, and smaller non-bank players face real consolidation pressure.

Separately: **Form 1099-DA now requires brokers to report cost basis** on digital asset transactions from January 1, 2026, filed in 2027. Gross proceeds reporting already began for 2025.

REALISTIC

Cost-basis reconstruction, for platforms and for whales

The industry's open secret is that cost basis data is a disaster. Every transfer between wallets and platforms breaks the chain. When basis reporting hits in the 2027 filing season, platforms face a wave of customer disputes and IRS mismatch notices, and large individual holders face genuinely painful reconstruction problems.

Build the reconciliation engine that repairs basis across chains and venues. Two markets: sell to platforms as infrastructure, or sell to high-net-worth individuals as a high-fee service. **Your friends know the wealthy holders** — that is the warmer, faster, better-paying half.

This is the same shape as the 835 scanner: messy transaction files in, reconciled truth out. You have already proven you can build it.

AMBITIOUS

Stablecoin issuer compliance infrastructure

The GENIUS Act obliges permitted issuers to hold qualifying reserves and publish regular attested disclosures. Large bank-affiliated issuers will build this internally. Smaller issuers cannot, and the rules land within months.

Build the reserve monitoring, attestation and disclosure reporting layer as a service. The timing is unusually precise for a regulatory play, and **your friends' platform relationships are exactly the design partners you'd need**. Risk: if final rules slip again, so does your market — and this space has burned people before.

CREATIVE

Crypto family office operations

The wealthiest people in crypto are frequently terrible at the boring parts: key management and inheritance, entity structuring, custody hygiene, charitable strategy, what happens if they die tomorrow. Traditional wealth managers don't understand the assets; crypto natives don't think about estates.

A discreet operations and structuring practice for large individual holders is high-fee, referral-gated, and almost impossible to enter cold. **It is entered exactly one way: through friends who know those people.** Which is what you have.

DOOR 03

Deep Foods

WHERE THE INDUSTRY ACTUALLY IS

Retail chargebacks run **1–5% of gross retail revenue** for vendors who don't actively manage them. Costco applies a 2% chargeback for packaging non-compliance and $5–10 per mislabeled carton. And the single leading cause of Costco supplier chargebacks is not packaging or quality — it is **inaccurate or late ASNs: data communication failures.**

Meanwhile AI demand forecasting has moved seasonal accuracy from roughly 50% to 82% in five months for some operators, cutting seasonal overproduction 40%.

REALISTIC

Retail deduction recovery — the scanner, for groceries

This is the strongest single idea in this document, and it is the business you have already built once.

Retailers deduct from supplier payments constantly — chargebacks, allowances, shortages, compliance penalties. Many are invalid or duplicated. Almost nobody disputes them, because reconciling a Costco deduction file against POs and ASNs is miserable manual work.

At 1–5% of gross retail revenue, a $150M manufacturer is leaking **$1.5M–7.5M a year**. Build the parser, categorize deductions, flag the invalid ones, generate disputes. Deep Foods is your customer zero and your proof. The NJ specialty-food manufacturing community is your referral network.

Pitch it in one sentence: *"Let me look at twelve months of your Costco and Trader Joe's deductions and tell you how much of it you should never have paid."*

AMBITIOUS

Demand forecasting built on cultural calendars

Off-the-shelf forecasting handles mainstream SKUs. It badly mishandles ethnic food, where demand spikes around Diwali, Ramadan, Navratri and regional festivals that move on lunar calendars and don't appear in any standard seasonality model.

Every specialty-food manufacturer either overproduces or stocks out around these events, every year. A forecasting layer trained on cultural calendars plus retail POS is genuinely differentiated, and the documented prize is a 40% cut in seasonal overproduction. Deep Foods can tell you in one conversation whether this is a real pain or one they've already solved.

CREATIVE

Be their co-packing pipeline

Deep's underused asset is manufacturing capacity and retail relationships. The hardest problem for any emerging food brand is finding a co-packer who'll take small volume seriously.

Broker the match: source emerging South Asian and adjacent food brands who need production, bring them to Deep as co-manufacturing customers, take a fee or an equity slice. You bring Deep incremental high-margin volume with no sales cost, and you get a portfolio of small brand positions for free. It also puts you inside the CPG world at zero capital.

DOOR 04

Amneal Pharmaceuticals

WHERE THE INDUSTRY ACTUALLY IS

DSCSA serialization is in full effect. There is a persistent **2–3% error rate in data files, quarantining thousands of products daily**, and the biggest operational headache across the supply chain is exception handling — mismatched transaction data, missing serial numbers, verification downtime.

Your instinct is right: a $6B public company with mature internal processes is not a customer for a first-time founder. So don't treat them as one.

REALISTIC

Ask for a day, not an order

The ask is: *"Can I spend a day with your supply chain or quality team to understand how DSCSA exceptions actually get resolved?"* That is flattering, costs them almost nothing, and gives you something no amount of research provides — the real workflow, in a real plant, from people who do it.

Amneal is a **teacher and a future reference**. The customers are the hundreds of mid-market manufacturers, repackagers and distributors with the same problem and no internal team to throw at it.

AMBITIOUS

DSCSA exception resolution for mid-market pharma

A 2–3% error rate across millions of transactions is a permanent manual reconciliation burden, and quarantined product is money frozen. Build the matching and resolution engine: ingest EPCIS data, identify the mismatch class, propose or automate the fix, track resolution.

Revenue per customer in pharma runs high. The obstacles are real — validation requirements are heavy and sales cycles are long — but the pain is present-tense rather than deadline-dependent, which is rarer than it sounds.

CREATIVE

Drug shortage prediction as portfolio intelligence

Generic manufacturers decide what to produce based on price, competition, and who else is exiting. Shortages are enormously profitable for whoever is positioned when one hits.

FDA publishes shortage data, ANDA holders, and inspection actions. A model that predicts which molecules are heading into shortage — from holders exiting, API supply concentration, facility warning letters — would be genuinely valuable to a generic portfolio team. All public data. And Amneal can tell you in one conversation whether they'd pay for it, which is the cheapest possible validation of a real product.

DOOR 05

Your cousin at Goldman

WHERE THE INDUSTRY ACTUALLY IS

82% of investment firms now use AI for deal sourcing research, and the share using it inside the investment decision itself doubled in a year. Bessemer reported reclaiming 234 hours per analyst.

REALISTIC

Use him as a sensor, not a customer

He sees deal flow, multiples, and what's actually getting funded in tech, media and telecom. One coffee a quarter asking "what are you seeing" is free, genuinely useful, and costs him nothing. He also knows what "impressive" looks like on paper, which matters when you eventually raise or sell.

AMBITIOUS

Exit readiness for founder-owned businesses

Roughly six million small and mid-sized businesses will change hands in the coming decade, and about 80% of those exits are companies under $2M — too small for bankers, poorly served by brokers. Most go to market unprepared: messy financials, no data room, no story, no quality-of-earnings work.

A productized exit-readiness service is a real business, and you have an unusual advisory bench for it: **a Goldman banker who knows what buyers want, and a cousin who has actually sold a company.** Fees are meaningful and the tailwind is demographic rather than regulatory.

CREATIVE

A seller-intent signal engine

288 private equity roll-up platforms compete for proprietary deal flow, and sourcing is their permanent bottleneck. Build a model that identifies owner-operated businesses likely to sell — entity registration age, absence of successors, lapsing licenses, declining permit activity, slowing review velocity, real estate ownership.

Sell the leads or the subscription. Your cousin validates whether the signal is worth anything and can introduce you to buyers, which are the two things that would otherwise take a year to learn.

DOOR 06

Your former VC boss

This one isn't really an idea question, so I'm going to treat it as what it is.

REALISTIC

Repair it with no ask attached

Send a short, honest note. You left abruptly, you didn't handle it well, you're sorry, you hope he's doing well. Nothing else. No update, no request, no hint.

People remember who apologised without wanting something. If a job or an introduction comes later, it comes because the relationship exists again. And it's worth doing whether or not anything follows — unfinished things like this cost more to carry than to resolve.

AMBITIOUS

Come back with work, not a résumé

Don't ask for the job. Pick three sectors, write genuinely excellent investment memos on them, and send one — unsolicited, with no ask. That's a far stronger reintroduction than a request, and it demonstrates the exact thing you said you'd now do better.

CREATIVE

Build the tool the firm needs, then hand it over

A sourcing or diligence tool aimed at their specific thesis. It re-opens the relationship on your terms, proves capability rather than claiming it, and might become a job, a product, or a customer. The appetite is documented — firms are actively reclaiming hundreds of analyst hours with exactly this kind of tooling.

ONE HONEST THING

You said the hard part wasn't the work — it was the anxiety of leading calls and not feeling fully prepared. AI genuinely fixes preparation. It does not fix the feeling of being on a call with people watching you.

That's worth thinking about before you aim at getting the same job back, because the same environment tends to produce the same experience. If you go back, go back having decided how you'll handle that part — not hoping better preparation dissolves it.

DOOR 07

Falguni Nayar and Nykaa

WHERE THE INDUSTRY ACTUALLY IS

Nykaa holds roughly 30% of India's online beauty market with 37M customers and 210 stores, but faces Myntra, Tata Cliq and Reliance's Tira, plus quick commerce. Beauty is already **Blinkit's second-largest category at 13.4% of daily sales**, and quick commerce's share of online beauty spending is projected to rise from ~16% to ~30% by FY30. Nykaa's answer is Nykaa Now, a 30-minute to 2-hour delivery service in key metros.

This is your least usable contact and the easiest to waste. Guard it.

REALISTIC

One conversation, later, for judgment

Not a pitch, not a customer, not an investor. When you have something real, ask for twenty minutes of advice. Someone who built a category-defining company from scratch in her fifties has pattern recognition you cannot buy, and asking for judgment is the one ask that doesn't cost the relationship.

AMBITIOUS

The India–US beauty and wellness bridge

Here is a genuine overlap between two of your contacts. Indian beauty and personal care brands — ayurvedic skincare, ethnic haircare, wellness — have almost no presence in mainstream US retail. Meanwhile the US South Asian population is over five million and increasingly affluent, and mainstream American retail is actively hunting for global beauty stories.

You have brand access on one side (Nykaa's ecosystem) and US retail distribution knowledge on the other (Deep Foods sells Costco and Trader Joe's). Being the entity that brings Indian BPC brands into US retail sits exactly at that intersection. Capital-light to start — you'd broker, not buy.

CREATIVE

Quick-commerce readiness

Ten-minute delivery is restructuring Indian retail, and it demands different pack sizes, different pricing, different assortment logic and different data practices than traditional ecommerce. Most brands are adapting badly and in a hurry.

A product or practice helping brands convert for q-commerce is well-timed. Honest caveat: executing in India without being there is hard, and this is the idea on this page most likely to fail on distance alone.

DOOR 08

Your cousin and Unitabac

WHAT JUST HAPPENED IN THIS INDUSTRY

In **April 2026 a federal court finalised that premium cigars are exempt from the FDA's Deeming Rule** — no product approval, no user fees, no deeming compliance. Companies had paid **over $100 million in user fees between 2016 and 2023** on products now held outside the rule. The global premium market is projected to grow from $10.3B in 2023 to $13.6B by 2030, across a fragmented landscape of 1,000+ US brands.

REALISTIC

He's your most valuable advisor and you haven't used him

Of everyone on this list, he is the only person who has done the exact thing you are trying to do: built something in an unglamorous industry and sold it to a public company. Not advised on it. Did it.

One long conversation about the middle years — what nearly killed it, what he'd skip, how the buyer actually found him — is worth more than several of the ideas in this document. There is no ask in that conversation, which makes it the easiest call you'll make. **Make it this week.**

AMBITIOUS

Consolidate premium cigar brands

A fragmented industry of 1,000+ brands, a market heading to $13.6B, and a decade-long regulatory overhang that lifted five months ago. That combination usually causes valuations to re-rate and owners who were waiting to exit to start moving.

Your cousin has completed an exit in this exact space, knows the operators and the acquirers, and would be a genuinely credible partner rather than a cheerleader. Capital-gated — which is what the Tarsadia and Goldman doors are theoretically for.

CREATIVE

The user fee question

Over $100M in FDA user fees were collected between 2016 and 2023 on products a federal court has now held were never subject to the rule. Whether any refund pathway exists is a real legal question that I cannot resolve from public sources — it may well be no.

But it's worth one phone call, because **your cousin will know in about ninety seconds** whether the industry has already looked at this. And even if refunds are impossible, the same research produces something valuable: a list of exactly which companies were carrying that cost, are now relieved of it, and have suddenly better economics. That is an acquisition target list assembled from public data.

DOOR 09

Your California friend

THE CLEAREST "DON'T" IN THIS DOCUMENT

California cannabis cultivation is in genuine collapse. Wholesale flower has fallen to roughly **$300–500 per pound against $1,400–1,600 in 2018**. Licensed cultivation grew 340% between 2018 and 2022 while legal sales grew 22%. An estimated 400–500 California dispensaries have closed. And **only 27% of cannabis companies were profitable in 2024, down from 42% two years earlier.**

Growers are selling below production cost. If your friend is serious about entering cultivation, showing him these numbers is the most valuable thing you could do for him this year.

WHERE THE BETTER OPPORTUNITY IS

Laundromats: unattended 24/7 operation is now the industry default, remote monitoring and dynamic pricing are affordable at single-owner scale, and **card-enabled locations command meaningfully higher acquisition multiples than coin-only stores.** Single stores trade at 3–5x SDE, multi-store operators at 4–6x EBITDA, in a market where revenue per store is rising as weaker sites close.

REALISTIC

Be the analyst on his laundromat deals

He has the capital and the appetite; you have the ability to build models and evaluate deals quickly. Do the underwriting: market demographics, machine age, utility costs, competitive density, upgrade economics. Paid, immediate, and it teaches you small-business acquisition from inside a live deal.

AMBITIOUS

A card-conversion roll-up

A documented value-add playbook: buy coin-only stores at 3–5x SDE, install card and app systems, capture revenue lift and customer data, exit the portfolio at a higher multiple. The mechanism is well-established, boring, cash-generative, and unglamorous enough that competition is thin.

He brings capital and operating appetite; you bring analysis, systems and technology. That is a real partnership rather than you asking for a favour.

CREATIVE

Find the sellers before the brokers do

The same seller-intent engine as the Goldman idea, pointed at laundromats: coin-only signals from reviews and street view, long-registered entities, aging owners, good demographics, no recent permits. Use it for his acquisitions, then sell it to the growing population of searchers doing exactly this. Almost no capital required and it compounds into a data asset.

DOOR 10

The Tarsadia family

THE THING WORTH KNOWING ABOUT THIS NETWORK

AAHOA's 20,000 members own 60% of all hotels in the United States and account for 1.4% of national GDP. That is one of the most concentrated business communities in America, and it is the community your network sits inside.

Its members are struggling with exactly the problems you're good at: **67% cite managing disparate systems as a top challenge, 27% run more than seven platforms, and 27% spend over eleven hours a week reconciling data.** Only 25% consider themselves ready to adopt AI. Meanwhile franchise fees run 10–12% of room revenue — $200,000–300,000 annually on a $2M property — and owners widely believe their mandatory marketing contributions never come back to their territory.

REALISTIC

Don't approach them. Approach the community.

You're right that Tarsadia is a "only with something real" contact. But the association is not. AAHOA has 20,000 members, regional chapters, a large annual convention, and a track record of endorsing vendors. That is a reachable channel that doesn't require a billionaire's introduction — and if you're succeeding inside it, the introduction becomes easy rather than necessary.

AMBITIOUS

Franchise fee and brand cost audit

This is the fourth door in the pattern from the top of this document, and it may be the largest. Hotel owners pay 10–12% of room revenue in royalties, marketing levies, loyalty program costs and reservation fees, calculated from statements almost nobody audits line by line. Errors, misapplied charges and unjustified levies are common in any billing regime that complex.

Same machine you've already built: parse the statements, compare against the franchise agreement, surface the discrepancies. On a $2M property the fee base is $200–300k, so even a small error rate is worth real money — and there are 20,000 owners in one association who talk to each other constantly.

CREATIVE

The nightly reconciliation layer

Twenty-seven percent of independent hotel operators spend more than eleven hours a week reconciling data across seven-plus systems. That is more than half a full-time job, per property, spent on something a piece of middleware should do.

A product that unifies PMS, OTA, POS and accounting into one nightly report is unglamorous and deeply wanted. AAHOA's existing official PMS partnership proves the association channel works for vendors who earn it.

DOOR 11

Uncle Rupen

WHERE THESE INDUSTRIES ACTUALLY ARE

Family entertainment centres are a **$34B market growing 10–12% annually**. Party deposits cut no-shows by 45%. Food and beverage is 30–40% of revenue at the best venues, and multi-activity concepts consistently beat single-attraction ones.

Restaurants are harder: full-service labour is trending to **35–40% of sales**, turnover exceeds 70% annually at $5,000+ per replacement, and 57% of operators say growing catering sales has been a struggle. Independent restaurants declined 2.3% in 2025.

REALISTIC

Become his operating analyst

He runs a kids' entertainment venue, luxury party halls, restaurants and real estate — and almost certainly has no unified view across them. Build it: booking utilisation by daypart, party conversion rate, F&B attach, labour as a percentage of sales, revenue per available hour.

It's paid work, it starts immediately, and it teaches you multi-unit operations from someone who has already built and sold a business. This is the fastest path to earning something on this entire page.

AMBITIOUS

Revenue management for independent venues

Deposits cut no-shows 45%; F&B attach drives 30–40% of revenue at top venues; most independent operators do neither systematically. Build booking, deposit and upsell optimisation for Xtreme Energy and the party halls first, then sell to the thousands of independent FECs and banquet halls in a market growing at double digits.

A live venue as design partner is exactly what makes a product like this credible to the next twenty buyers.

CREATIVE

The South Asian wedding platform

Indian weddings are multi-day, extraordinarily high-budget events coordinated almost entirely through WhatsApp threads and spreadsheets. Vendor coordination, guest logistics, multi-event scheduling, and payments across a dozen suppliers are all done by hand.

Average transaction values are enormous, the vertical is genuinely underserved by mainstream wedding software, and **your uncle owns the supply side —** halls, restaurants, catering. Start as the operating system for his venues, expand to the vendor network around them. Your community is the market, which is the rarest kind of advantage.

The overlaps

You asked me to look for these specifically. Four are real.

1. The deduction machine — four markets, one engine

Covered at the top. Medical underpayments, retail chargebacks, franchise fees, and possibly FDA user fees are the same problem with different file formats. **You have built it once and have a personal door into all four.** This is the highest-conviction observation in this document.

2. Deep Foods × Nykaa — the consumer bridge

US retail distribution knowledge on one side, Indian brand access on the other, and a growing affluent South Asian population in between. Bringing Indian beauty and food brands into US retail is capital-light if you broker rather than buy.

3. The Indian-American business community as a distribution channel

Look at what your contacts have in common: food manufacturing, pharma, hotels (60% of US hotels via AAHOA), physicians, event venues. This is a dense, high-trust, referral-driven community concentrated in New Jersey and California, and **one credible engagement inside it travels much further than one credible engagement in a cold market.** Whatever you build, this is your first hundred customers.

4. Cigar cousin × Goldman cousin × Tarsadia — the acquisition stack

If you ever pursue a roll-up — cigars, laundromats, anything fragmented — you have someone who has done an exit, someone who understands buyers and valuation, and a potential capital source. Most first-time acquirers have none of those.

If I were you, this week

Not eleven conversations. Three, plus the thing already in motion.

1. **Your cigar cousin.** No ask, no pitch. "How did you actually do it?" He is the only person on this list who has completed the journey you're starting, and this is the easiest call you will make.
2. **Deep Foods.** One question: *"How much do Costco and Trader Joe's deduct from your payments each year, and does anyone check whether those deductions are right?"* If the answer is a shrug, you have found your second business and you already know how to build it.
3. **Uncle Rupen.** Offer to build him a proper operating dashboard across the venues. Paid work, this month, and an education in running things.
4. **Keep the 835 files moving.** Everything above is more useful once you have shipped something real to one physician.

> **THE THING TO HOLD ONTO**
>
> Every idea we killed over the last three weeks died from something invisible from the outside — a market too small, a buyer who wouldn't pay, an incumbent who'd fix it for free. You now have eleven people who can see those things from the inside, before you build.
>
> That is worth more than any single idea in this document.

Prepared September 2026 from public sources current to this date. Industry figures are cited from published research and should be re-verified before you rely on them commercially. The FDA user fee refund question in Door 08 is genuinely unresolved and is flagged as a question to ask, not a conclusion. Nothing here is legal, tax or investment advice.